

Arashk Afshar

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Fields

Public Economics, Political Economy, Microeconomic Theory

Education

PhD	Rutgers University , Economics	2027
	• Advisor and Dissertation Committee Chair: Oriol Carbonell-Nicolau	
MA	Rutgers University , Economics	2023
BA	University of Washington Tacoma , Business Administration (Finance)	Tacoma, WA
	• Summa Cum Laude	2019
BS	University of Washington Tacoma , Mathematics	2019
	• Magna Cum Laude	
AA	Green River College , Business	Auburn, WA
	• Highest Honors	2016

Job Market Paper

Saving as a Luxury Good: Why Progressive Taxation Cannot Guarantee Falling Inequality

- When the rich save a systematically larger share of their wealth, no conventional tax instrument inherits the classical guarantee that progressivity compresses the distribution. The wealth tax alone reaches accumulated wealth at its source, yet what governs the long-run trajectory is not the tax rate but the elasticity of retention — how post-tax wealth scales with pre-tax wealth at the top — which every enacted or proposed wealth tax leaves essentially undisturbed. The debate has been conducted over the wrong parameter.

Working Papers

The Myth of the Informed Voter

- A model of political campaigns in which advertising manipulates voters by directing their attention to issues chosen by candidates, who are selected by elites. Under unlimited campaign funding the equilibrium favors more extreme candidates; restricting funding shifts it toward a more moderate candidate and a better-informed electorate, offering an equilibrium rationale for campaign-finance limits without abandoning voter rationality.

Saving as Instrument and Status: Progressive Taxation in a Dynamic Economy (Work in Progress)

- Extends the static analysis to a life-cycle economy, where saving carries additional force as both an instrument and a marker of status; preliminary work suggests this strengthens the case for marginal progressivity.

Teaching

Econ 440: Economics of Income Inequality and Discrimination

- Designed the course and syllabus from a dormant catalog listing.

Rutgers University — Instructor of Record
2025, 2026

Econ 402: Labor Economics

- Designed the syllabus and introduced a research-project-based assessment.

Rutgers University — Instructor of Record
2024, 2025

Econ 320: Intermediate Microeconomic Analysis

- Taught from a fully calculus-based treatment, including sections of seventy-five.

Rutgers University — Instructor of Record
2023, 2025

College Writing 101

Rutgers University, Department of English — Instructor
Jan 2024

Awards and Honors

- Sidney I. Simon Award (2024) — outstanding teaching by a graduate student, Department of Economics, Rutgers University
- Nominated, President's Medal, University of Washington Tacoma
- Interdisciplinary Award, University of Washington Tacoma
- Pi Mu Epsilon, Beta Gamma Sigma, and Phi Theta Kappa honor societies

Skills

Programming: Python, R, Stata, MATLAB, LaTeX

Service

- Volunteer Tax Preparer, United Way of King County
- Volunteer Tutor, University of Washington Tacoma and Green River College

Languages

Languages: English (fluent); Farsi (native)

References

- Oriol Carbonell-Nicolau (Advisor and Committee Chair), Professor of Economics, Rutgers University — carbonell-nicolau@rutgers.edu
- Richard P. McLean, Distinguished Professor of Economics, Rutgers University — rpmclean@economics.rutgers.edu
- Andrew Mackenzie, Assistant Professor of Economics, Rutgers University — andrew.k.mackenzie@rutgers.edu